Chapter Forty-Three

The Tran Dynasty

Between 1224 and 1257,
a new royal family rules the Dai Viet,
a new nation breaks away from the Khmer,
and the Cham try to dominate the south

THE KING OF THE DAI VIET was not well.

Hue Tong of the Ly dynasty had been on the throne for fourteen years. His road to the throne had been a rutted and difficult one; before he was fifteen, his father, King Cao Tong, had been driven from the throne by a palace revolt. The royal family had fled to Nam Dinh Province, where they took refuge with the wealthiest family on the coast: the Tran, made prosperous by generations of skillful fishing. In exile, Crown Prince Hue Tong had married the young daughter of the house. This brought the entire Tran clan firmly over to his side, and with the help of his new wife's father and brothers, the crown prince and the king were able to return to their capital city of Thang Long.

In 1210, at Cao Tong's death, Hue Tong had assumed the throne of the Dai Viet. Still only seventeen years old, dependent on his in-laws for support and direction, Hue Tong had promoted his wife's male relatives into higher and higher positions at court. Now thirty years old, the king had Tran